

The Three Steles of Seth

Codex Reference: VII,5

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by James E. Goehring

Translated by James M. Robinson

The Three Steles of Seth offers a rare view into the worship practice of a Gnostic Sethian community. These Gnostics identified their teachings with the primal revelation of God to Adam, which had passed through Seth to his descendants (The Apocalypse of Adam, V,5). Lost and forgotten for ages, this Sethian gnosis had been revealed anew in the latter days. The recipients of this renewed revelation understood themselves as “the living and unshakable race” (118,12-13), the true latter-day descendants of Seth (hence the modern label of Sethian Gnosticism). The Three Steles of Seth is presented as part of this latter-day revelation, in this case to Dositheos, the supposed Samaritan founder of Gnosticism.

The text, which shows no Christian influence, is indebted to Jewish and Neoplatonic traditions. In Genesis, Seth marks a new beginning after the tragic conflict between Cain and Abel (Gn 3:25-5:8). Appointed by God to replace Abel, he is a son in the likeness of his father Adam, as Adam is in the likeness of God. It is in his time that “men began to call upon the name of the Lord.” According to the first-century Jewish historian Josephus (Ant. 1,67-71), Seth’s descendants continued to follow his godfearing ways for seven generations, after which they too fell into a life of depravity. During this time, they preserved and added to the knowledge transmitted by Adam to Seth. Forewarned of impending divine judgements by water and fire, they preserved this knowledge for future generations on two steles, one of stone to survive the flood and one of brick to survive the fire.

This legend accounts for the presentation of the present text as the content of steles attributed to Seth (cf. Zost. 130,1-4 and Gos. Eg. 68,10-23). The expansion from the original two steles in the Jewish legend to three represents the influence of Neoplatonic conceptions of the divine triad. The three steles or hymnic prayers of the present text are addressed in ascending order to the threefold nature of god: the Self-begotten Son, the male virgin Barbelo (mother), and the Unbegotten Father.

Ecstatic trips through the heavens are well attested in Sethian Gnosticism. The Sethian tractates Zostrianos and Allogenes record such journeys by the seers for which the texts were named. These accounts, however, record what was revealed to the seer in his ascent. The invocations of the seer to the divine triad are only noted in passing, as when Zostrianos affirms, “I joined with them all and blessed the Kalyptos aeon and the virgin Barbelo and the Invisible Spirit. I became all-perfect.” In The Three Steles of Seth these blessings or hymnic prayers are recorded in full.

Since Allogenes may be interpreted as another name for Seth, both tractates may commemorate the ascent of the community’s primal ancestor to the divine triad. However, while Allogenes

records for edification what was revealed to the seer, *The Three Steles of Seth* preserves the invocations of the seer as a prototype to serve the latter-day Sethian community in its liturgical reenactment of his ascent. While the hymnic prayers are set forth in the tractate as prayers of Seth, first person plural references in the text (e.g. 124,17-18) betray the use of the prayers in the worship practice of the community. The text has led Hans Martin Schenke to posit the existence of a Sethian mystery of ascension. The three subdivisions of the text thus correspond to the three stages or levels in the worshippers' ascent to the threefold nature of god, since at the conclusion of the tractate one must return from the third back down to the second and first.

Neoplatonic philosophical terminology abounds in the text, especially the Existence-Life-Mind triad in the deity. The terminology is also found in the related tractates of *Zostrianos*, *Allogenes*, and *Marsanes*, which together form a cluster of Sethian Gnostic texts with close ties to Neoplatonism. *Zostrianos* and *Allogenes* are both mentioned by Porphyry in his *Life of Plotinus* as texts refuted by Plotinus, who taught a course "Against the Gnostics" in 265-266 C.E. Thus a dating for this stage of Sethian Gnosticism and therefore for *The Three Steles of Seth* is suggested. Provenience is uncertain, though the philosophical nature of the text would be much at home in Alexandria, Egypt.

The scribal note at the end of the text (127,28-32) has been variously interpreted as applying to *The Three Steles of Seth* alone or to the codex as a whole.